ETON Advanced French Grammar: Specialists

EW 11

64. Tenses used with SI in sentences expressing a condition

In all cases *si* is followed by the same tense as `if' in English:

SUBORDINATE CLAUSE WITH `IF' OR *SI*	**MAIN CLAUSE**
If your mother comes tonight	we will go to the cinema
Si ta mère vient ce soir	*nous irons au cinéma*
There are only 3 possible tenses in the `if' clause.	Corresponding tenses in the main clause.
PRESENT (finish, come, see, work)	**FUTURE**
If she finishes at 6 o'clock	we will go to the theatre
Si elle finit à 6 heures	*nous irons au théâtre*
PAST (finished, came, saw, worked)	**CONDITIONAL**
If she finished at 6 o'clock	we would go to the theatre
Si elle finissait à 6 heures	*nous irions au théâtre*
PLUPERFECT (had finished, had come, had seen, had worked)	**CONDITIONAL PERFECT**
If she had finished at 6 o'clock	we would have gone to the theatre
Si elle avait fini à 6 heures	*nous serions allé(e)s au théâtre*

NB *si* beginning a sentence can NEVER be followed by the Future or Conditional. However, if it comes in the middle of a sentence and the 'if' can be replaced by 'whether', without altering the meaning, *si* can be followed by the future or conditional.

- If it rains tomorrow I shall stay in : *S'il pleut demain je resterai chez moi*
- I wonder if (= whether) it will rain tomorrow : *Je me demande s'il pleuvra demain*

NB `If he' = *s'il*; `If she' = *si elle*; `If they' = *s'ils*; `If they' = *si elles*

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65. The hidden future

After certain conjunctions of time, the future tense must be used in French when future time is implied, or used, in the main clause. Some common conjuctions are:

i) as soon as	:	**dès que** *or* **aussitôt que**	ii) as long as	:	**tant que**
iii) once	:	**une fois que**	iv) after	:	**après que**
v) when	:	**quand** *or* **lorsque**	vi) while	:	**pendant que**

NB

Every time you write one of these conjunctions you should ask yourself whether or not the verb which is in the main clause indicates an event that has already happened, or an event which will happen in the future. If the latter case is true the tense you use in French depends on the tense in the English clause :

a) English PRESENT : French FUTURE

- I will do it when I have (= WILL HAVE) time — *Je le ferai quand j'aurai le temps*
- Call me as soon as he arrives (= WILL ARRIVE) — *Appelle-moi dès qu'il arrivera*

b) English PERFECT : French FUTURE PERFECT

- He will reply after he has seen you = (WILL HAVE SEEN) — *Il répondra après qu'il t'aura vu*

You should also complete the pre-test exercises as part of your EW

In proses the narrative is often expressed in the past tenses, when events are related that have already happened. You should be aware that characters often mention events which, as they spoke, had not yet happened: the fact that they were «future» events in the past means that they cannot be conveyed by the perhaps more obvious perfect or pluperfect tenses, since these are tenses which indicate completed events. Hence French uses the conditional and conditional perfect tenses in cases such as the following:

c) English SIMPLE PAST and IMPERFECT : French CONDITIONAL
- He promised to do it as soon as he arrived (**Clearly he had not yet arrived, therefore** . . .)
  Il a promis de le faire aussitôt qu'il arriverait

d) English PLUPERFECT : French CONDITIONAL IN THE PAST (Conditional Perfect)
- He said he would act once the others had gone (**Clearly they had not yet gone therefore** . . .)
  Il a dit qu'il agirait une fois que les autres seraient partis

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66. *Venir de* + INFINITIVE

This structure can ONLY be used in the **PRESENT** or the **IMPERFECT** tense

a) HAVE/HAS JUST : present tense of *venir de*

- My friend has just arrived : *Mon ami vient d'arriver*

b) HAD JUST : imperfect tense of *venir de*

- He had just finished his homework : *Il venait de finir son devoir*

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67. Faillir faire quelque chose

English : NARROWLY AVOIDED DOING SOMETHING / NEARLY DID SOMETHING / ALMOST DID SOMETHING

- I nearly fell into the water : *J'ai failli tomber dans l'eau*
- He had narrowly avoided knocking her down : *Il avait failli la renverser*

NB *faillir* can only be used in the passé composé, the past historic or the pluperfect

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68. MOST

- Most + PLURAL NOUN : *La plupart des . . .* **+ PLURAL VERB**
- Most + SINGULAR NOUN : *La plus grande partie du/de la . . .* **+ SING. VERB**

- Most of the customers are women : *La plupart des clients sont des femmes*
- John ate most of the cake : *C'est Jean qui a mangé la plus grande partie du gâteau*
- Most of the cake was eaten by Jean : *La plus grande partie du gâteau a été mangée par Jean*

one exception : Most of the time : *la plupart du temps*

You should also complete the pre-test exercises as part of your EW

69. *Ce + être +* article / demonstrative adjective / possessive adjective

Where any part of the verb *être* is followed by an article (*un/une/des*; *le/la/les*), a demonstrative adjective (*ce*, *(cet)*, *cette*, *ces*) or a possessive adjective (*mon*, *ma*, *mes*, *ton*, *ta*, *tes* etc) the SUBJECT PRONOUN is ALWAYS *ce*:

- She's the woman who found it : *C'est la femme qui l'a trouvé*
- They're the men I was talking about : *Ce sont les hommes dont je parlais*
- He's the boy who borrowed my bike : *C'est le garçon qui a emprunté mon vélo*
- It's that girl who won : *C'est cette fille qui a gagné*
- It's this bike which was stolen : *C'est ce vélo qui a été volé*
- He is my best friend : *C'est mon meilleur ami*
- They are my best friends : *Ce sont mes meilleurs amis*